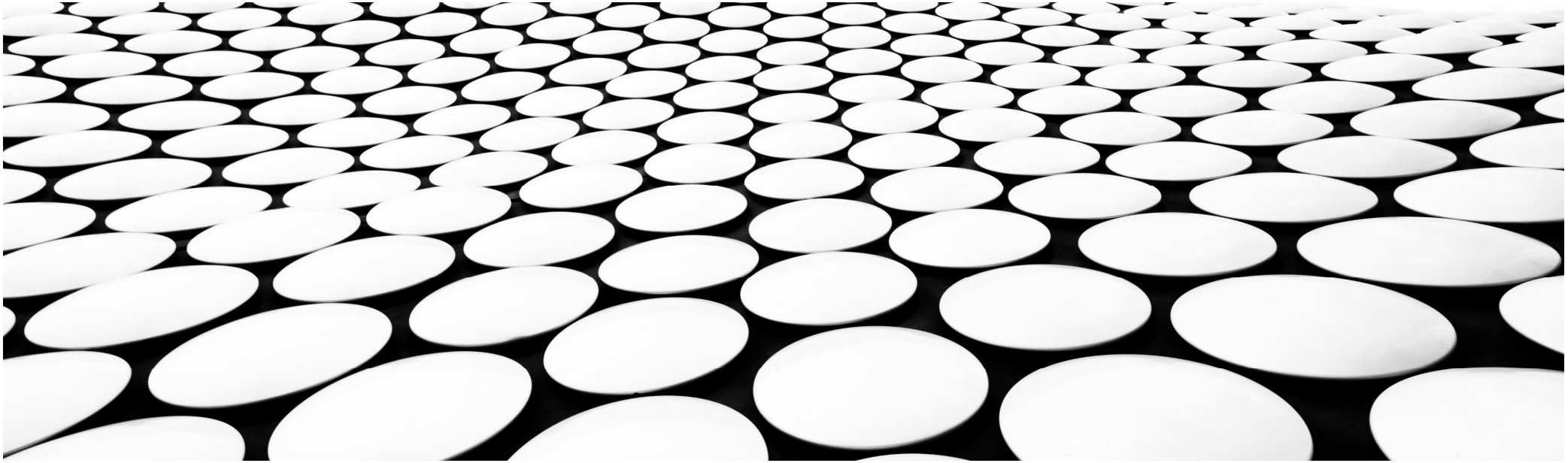
SHOOTING FOR THE (SPRINT) GOAL

THE IMPORTANCE OF SETTING GOOD SPRINT GOALS IN SCRUM



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SHOOTING FOR THE (SPRINT) GOAL

- What is a Sprint Goal and who sets it?
- Why is it important?
- How can we set better Sprint Goals?
- What challenges do we face?
- How does this apply to me?

WHAT IS SCRUM?

<u>Scrum Guide Definition:</u>

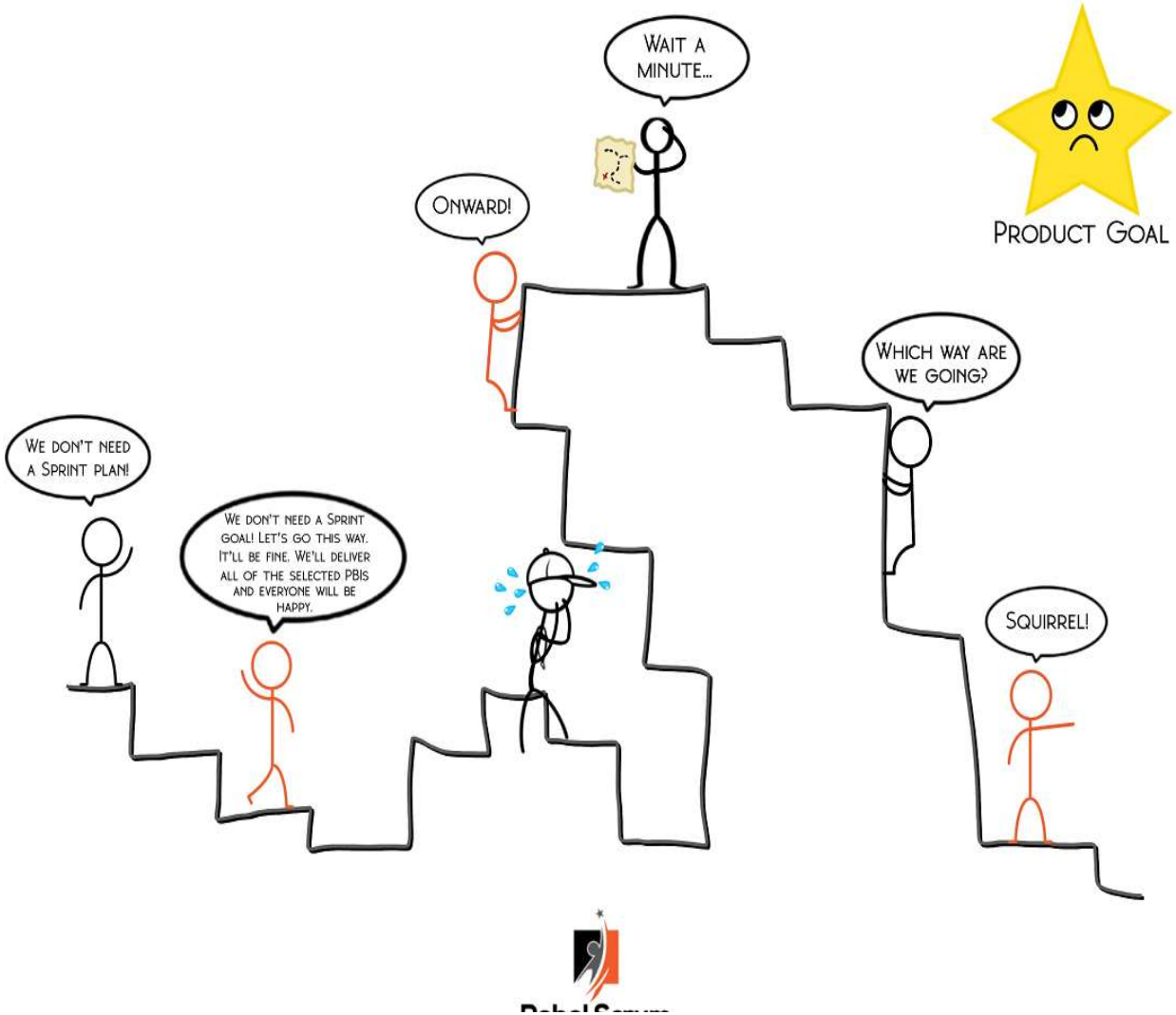
1. A Product Owner orders the work for a complex problem into a Product Backlog.
2. The Scrum Team turns a selection of the work into an Increment of value during a Sprint.
3. The Scrum Team and its stakeholders inspect the results and adjust for the next Sprint.
4. Repeat

THE SPRINT GOAL

- At Sprint Planning the Scrum Team ask “Why is this sprint valuable?”
- What will I be able to do with the product at the end of the sprint that I can’t do now?
- The Sprint Goal tells you “why” you are doing the work, e.g. “Update My User Details”
- In order to achieve the Sprint Goal we select a set of Backlog Items – the “what” – e.g.
  - Change my email address
  - Change my password
  - Add an avatar
- Note that the **Scrum Team** sets the Sprint Goal – this is the team’s **Commitment** for the next Sprint

WHY SET A SPRINT GOAL?

- The Sprint Goal is the single objective for the Sprint
- At the daily stand up the team replans to ensure they are on track to deliver the Sprint Goal
- If the work turns out to be different to what was expected the team can negotiate with the Product Owner to change the scope of the backlog as long as that does not affect the Sprint Goal
  - E.g. we could deliver “Update My User Details” without “Add an avatar”
- Setting a Sprint Goal allows the team to collaborate and innovate on delivering functionality without obsessing on completing a fixed number of work items



BENEFITS OF A SPRINT GOAL - FOCUS & COHERENCE

- I know *why* I am doing the work I'm doing
  - I can innovate to deliver the best solutions
  - Without a sprint goal I just have a bunch of "things" to do – a Sprint Goal gives me purpose
- The team works together to deliver the product increment
  - Increase Teamwork
  - Reduce siloing

BENEFITS OF A SPRINT GOAL
- DELIVERING SOMETHING USEFUL EVERY SPRINT

- Getting used to success
  - Who doesn't want to succeed every two weeks instead of waiting months and months to see if what we've done is correct?
- Better estimation
  - We know what functionality we've delivered not just what tickets got closed
- More opportunities to get feedback on what we've built
  - The first principle on the Agile Manifesto is "Our highest priority is to satisfy the customer through early and continuous delivery of valuable software"
  - If what we've built is wrong, never mind because we have an opportunity to pivot and try something else
  - More opportunities to tell if we are on track

BENEFITS OF A SPRINT GOAL - BETTER MEETINGS

- Daily Scrum
  - An opportunity to review progress toward the Sprint Goal and replan as necessary to ensure it is delivered
  - This may mean adjusting the Sprint Backlog
  - The team can replan *throughout* the day as necessary
- Sprint Review
  - Is no longer just a bunch of unrelated “things” that were done it now has a focus
  - Did the team achieve the Sprint Goal?
- Sprint Planning
  - Has a purpose – what is the Sprint Goal and how will we achieve it?
- Retrospective
  - Did we achieve the Sprint Goal?
    - If yes, did we do anything different that helped us?
    - If no, is there anything we could do differently next time?

SETTING BETTER SPRINT GOALS

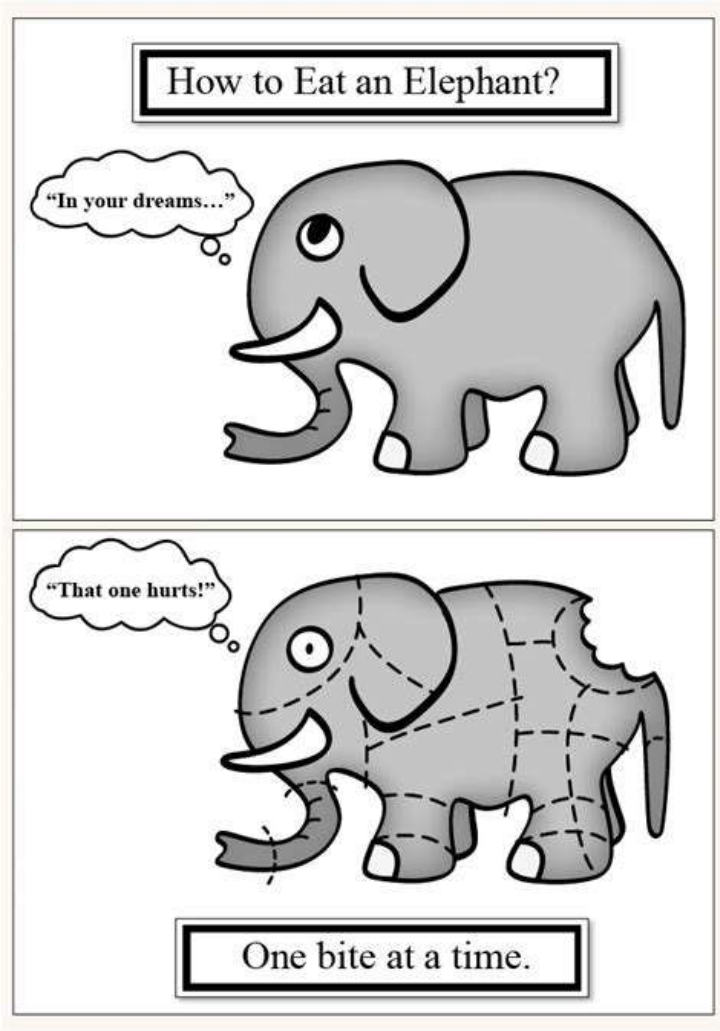
- Useful/Valuable
  - Has an “Outcome” rather than “Output” (i.e. number of tickets closed)
- Measurable
- Flexible
- Achievable
- Does not prevent you from doing other work, e.g.
  - Unplanned work
  - Tech Debt
  - Bug Fixes
- Determined by the whole Scrum Team

CHALLENGES/OBJECTIONS

- We can't set a single sprint goal
  - Everyone is working on a different area of the product
    - This is a perfect use case for setting a coherent Sprint Goal – break work down into deliverable chunks that the whole team can work on
  - Everyone is working on different projects
    - See above! Focussing on projects one at a time means a higher likelihood of delivering each one
- We can't fit the work in to a sprint
  - Reduce the scope – maybe Sprint Goal 1 is read the data and Sprint Goal 2 is update it, for example.
- We need to build the back end before we can build the front end
  - See above! Vertical slices allow the front and back end to evolve in unison which greatly increases the chance of getting both right and greatly reduces the chance of introducing redundancy in the API because the front and back end can determine the minimal data needed.
- We don't understand the Product Goal – it's not well defined
  - Ask questions at Sprint Planning if you can – if not you could make assumptions but document them and present them at the Sprint Review.

HOW DOES THIS APPLY TO ME?

- We don't do Scrum
  - Still break any project into smaller, coherent iterations – even home projects, e.g. DIY
- I'm not the Scrum Master/my company dictates "how" we "Do Scrum"
  - Retrospective is an opportunity to suggest a new approach
  - Remember the whole Scrum Team sets the Sprint Goal not an individual role
  - Is anyone *preventing* you from setting Sprint Goals?



FURTHER READING

- https://scrumguides.org/scrum-guide.html